## 2.3.2 Breast feeding



The Infant should be put to breast within half an hour after normal delivery and within 4 hours after caesarean sections. Prelacteal foods like honey, distilled water, glucose should not be given.

### a) Colostrum

During the first two or three days after delivery, thick and yellowish fluid is secreted from the mammary gland. This differs from the regular milk and is called **"colostrum".** It is secreted in small quantity of about 10- 40 ml which is rich in protein. Colostrum is the first immunization to the infant. It contains an interferon like substance which possesses strong antiviral activity. Colostrum contains B12 binding protein which renders B12 unavailable for the growth of E. coli and other bacteria. It also contains antibodies against viral diseases such as smallpox, polio, measles and influenza. Enzymes like lysozyme, peroxidase and xanthine oxidize that promote cell malnutrition are found to be more in colostrum. Colostrum contains large quantities of protective substances and enhances the development and maturation of the baby's gastrointestinal track. Colostrum helps a baby pass his or her first stool.




Breastfeeding can actually reduce baby's risk of disease later in life including type 1 and 2 diabetes, Hodgkin's disease, leukaemia, obesity, high blood pressure, high cholesterol levels, ulcerative colitis, asthma, eczema and also lowers risk for sudden infant death syndrome (SIDS)

**Table 2.7 Composition of Colostrum**

| Nutrient | Amount |
|---|---|
| Energy kcal | 58 |
| Fat g | 2.9 |
| Calcium mg | 31 |
| Phosphorous mg | 14 |
| Iron mg | 0.09 |
| Protein g | 2.7 |
| Lactose g | 5.3 |
| Carotene I.U | 186 |
| Vitamin A I.U | 296 |

### b) Transition milk

During the next two weeks, the milk increases in quantity and changes in appearance and composition. This is called **"transition milk".** The immunoglobin and protein content decreases while the fat and sugar content increases. Exclusive breastfeeding of colostrum and transition milk minimises infections related to neonatal deaths. The composition of milk changes even during the length of a single feed to exactly suit the need of a particular baby.

## 2.3.3 Advantages of breast feeding

Breastfeeding is not only beneficial to the infant but also to the mother. The advantages of breastfeeding can be considered under nutritional, immunological, psychological, economical and physiological and other factors.




Body is constantly making the perfect milk for baby. Milk changes its nutritional profile as baby grows (milk made for a 3 month old is different than for a 9 month old) milk can even change day to day. For example water content may increase during times of hot weather and baby sickness to provide extra hydration.



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